*recruit bachelor's level social workers and create these pipelines where we really support and create this learning thing."—Key Informant*

Barriers to accessing behavioral health needs include the following:

- Stigma: In a small community, people may worry about being seen accessing services or running into their provider in public. This stigma may make people uncomfortable seeking services.

  *"If people are stigmatized by going there to the local place [for behavioral health services], then we need a lot of resources for other places or for more confidential off-site. Again, that small town mentality of, 'I'm going to see [my provider] at the grocery store.'"—Key Informant*

- Unwillingness to seek care: People may not see their substance use/misuse as an issue and opt not to seek services. Seeking help is usually voluntary and people may not be ready for help.
- Cost of care: Behavioral health services can be expensive and not everyone may be able to afford the care.

Telehealth services, particularly in response to COVID-19, may have reduced some of these barriers, particularly some of the stigma of accessing care in a small community.

Key informants were particularly concerned about the mental health of the following groups:

- School-aged children: There is a need for more mental health resources for students to address the increasing mental health needs. Key informants shared they have seen an increase in mental health and behavioral challenges in school-aged children since the COVID-19 pandemic. They would also like to see young people develop healthier coping skills for stress.

  *"We have seen a tremendous rise in concerning behaviors and need for [addressing] mental health concerns with [school-age children]."—Key Informant*

- Young adults: Young adults out of high school or in their early twenties are in a transitional phase of learning to be independent. Key informants were concerned about substance use/misuse for this group and spoke to the importance of mentorship and support as these young people seek employment and stability.

Key informants also spoke to social connection as an important component of mental health. Living in a more remote area means that people need to rely on one another. Engaging with people creates wellness and good social connections make people less likely to rely on negative coping strategies.

*"I think when people have negative coping strategies, really what we're looking at is social connection. When people have really good social connection, they don't want those other things."—Key Informant*